

# DECLINE AND FALL

**N**othing lasts forever. Not the cruel Colosseum, not the gory games, not even the mighty Roman Empire. From the middle of the 3rd century CE, Rome was struggling to keep out the barbarian tribes that were attacking the frontiers of its territory. To make things worse, emperors and would-be emperors were constantly fighting among themselves. And as for the Christians ... well, they just wouldn't go away.

## Historic moment

The Battle of the Milvian Bridge, fought outside the city of Rome in October 312 CE, was a turning point in Roman history. At this battle, Constantine, the Western emperor, defeated his rival Maxentius, emperor of Italy. Before the battle, Constantine had a vision in which the Christian god showed a cross to him and said, "In this sign, conquer!" He believed that the god of the Christians had come to his aid. In gratitude, Constantine allowed Christians to worship as they wished. The days of persecution were over, and the first Christian churches were built in Rome.

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EMPEROR CONSTANTINE STOPPED THE PERSECUTION OF CHRISTIANS. HE STARTED TO FOLLOW CHRISTIAN WAYS HIMSELF.

